

Professor Bartholomew Armah

Senior Economic Adviser to the CEO, AUDA-NEPAD

Midrand, Republic of South Africa

Former Acting Director, Economic Affairs Division,

United Nations Economic Commission for Africa

Email: bartholomewa@auda-nepad.org

website: www.barmah1.org

WhatsApp: +1-414-243-3307

27 April 2026

The Admissions Committee

Eller College of Management

University of Arizona

Tucson, Arizona, United States of America

Reference for Mr Marlon Lezama, Master of Science in Artificial Intelligence for Business

To the Members of the Admissions Committee,

I write with great enthusiasm to support the application of Mr Marlon Lezama for the Master of Science in Artificial Intelligence for Business. I am presently the Senior Economic Adviser to the CEO of AUDA-NEPAD, the development agency of the African Union, based in South Africa. Prior to my present appointment, I served for several years as Acting Director of the Macroeconomics and Governance Division of the United Nations Economic Commission for Africa, retiring from the United Nations system in 2024, and earlier held a tenured Associate professorial appointment at the University of Wisconsin-Milwaukee in the United States. I have therefore had the unusual benefit of observing Mr Lezama from three vantage points in succession: that of a senior multilateral colleague during our joint tenure at UNECA, that of an academic, and now that of a continental policy adviser working on the African development issues that he helped to orchestrate and implement.

My direct knowledge of Mr Lezama dates from his arrival at UNECA in 2015 and was sustained through to his retirement from the Commission in August 2022. Throughout that period, he led the Partnerships, Resource Mobilisation and Technical Cooperation function in the Office of the Executive Secretary, while my Division provided the analytical and policy substance that underpinned the Commission's flagship economic work. Ours was a sustained intellectual

partnership rather than a transactional one, and I came to know him as a colleague of unusual rigour, independence of mind, and steadiness under pressure.

Our most consequential collaboration was on the post pandemic economic recovery initiative negotiated with the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, which mobilised in excess of US\$12 million for analytical and policy support to African Member States on liquidity expansion, investment financing, debt sustainability, and the formulation of debt consolidation strategies. Mr Lezama led the partnership architecture, the negotiation with the Foundation, and the drafting of the Theory of Influence framework that anchored the programme. My Division provided the macroeconomic substance and framing for the programme. The reason the proposal succeeded, in my professional opinion, was the unusual quality of the dialogue between the two streams of work. Mr Lezama did not merely package the economics for donor consumption. He engaged seriously with the substantive issues, challenged the framing where he thought it was weak, and elevated the policy reasoning rather than diluting it. That capacity to operate as an intellectual peer across disciplines is rare among programme leaders of his seniority.

I observed the same quality across our other shared work, including the African Continental Free Trade Area implementation programme, the Programme for Infrastructure Development in Africa, and the domestic resource mobilisation initiative that grew out of the Thabo Mbeki High Level Panel report on illicit financial flows from Africa. In each case he combined the operational discipline of a senior delivery manager with the analytical curiosity of a researcher. He read widely, asked the kind of questions one expects from a seasoned practitioner rather than a programme officer, and was unafraid to revise his own positions when the evidence pointed elsewhere.

It is therefore not a surprise to me that Mr Lezama achieved a distinction level result of 95.7 per cent on the University of Oxford Artificial Intelligence Programme delivered by the Saïd Business School earlier this year, against a class average of 83.0 per cent across a cohort of 885 participants. Nor is it a surprise that he is now writing a book on the ethics and governance of Artificial General Intelligence, has constructed at his own initiative and expense, a Linux and NVIDIA DGX Spark research environment for deploying open weight models, and intends to follow the Master of Science with doctoral research on the gap between the pace of AI advancement and the institutional capacity of human governance systems to absorb it. Drawing on my earlier experience as a university professor in the United States, I find this trajectory unusually well calibrated. The AI ethics and governance field is overwhelmingly populated by

computer scientists, engineers and philosophers. It is severely under populated by senior practitioners who have spent four decades inside the multilateral institutions whose adaptation will determine whether AI deployment is governed well or badly. Mr Lezama is exactly that kind of practitioner, and the AI scholarly community will be the better for his presence in it.

For a programme oriented toward the application of artificial intelligence to business and institutional decision making, I can think of few candidates better suited. Mr Lezama brings an exceptional record of senior delivery, a demonstrated capacity for advanced study, and a long term research vision that the Master of Science programme will materially advance. He will also be a generous and engaged member of the cohort, particularly for classmates who come to AI from technical backgrounds and who stand to benefit from his perspective on the institutional environments in which AI will be deployed.

I recommend him without hesitation and at the highest level available to me. I would be glad to discuss this recommendation further at the Committee's convenience.

Yours faithfully,

Professor Bartholomew Armah

Senior Economic Adviser to the CEO of AUDA NEPAD

Former Acting Director, Economic Affairs Division

United Nations Economic Commission for Africa

Email: bartholomewa@auda-nepad.org